



MONTANA FISH, WILDLIFE & PARKS

Additional Fall 2024–Winter 2025 Wolf and other Species Trapping Regulations Within and Outside the Geographic Scope Identified by Federal Court Order

On Nov. 12th, 2024 the Montana Fish and Wildlife Commission adopted additions to the printed 2024/2025 Wolf, Furbearer, and Trapping Regulations.

Supplemental Trapping Permit Requirement: Effective Dec. 1, 2024, ALL trappers conducting trapping activities (except those using water sets or live cage traps) inside of the geographic scope identified by federal court order (see map on the next page) must obtain a free “Supplemental Trapping Permit” when targeting nongame (raccoon, badger, red fox) and predatory animals (coyote, striped skunk, spotted skunk, weasel). This includes those trappers already holding a valid trapping license.

Trapping for Livestock Protection Requirements: Trappers conducting trapping activities for livestock protection inside of the geographic scope identified by federal court order must complete and sign a declaration identifying the producer’s name, that the producer has provided permission for trapping activities to occur on their private or leased property, and the county where such activities will occur. Landowners trapping for livestock protection on their own lands or lands they have leased for livestock production are exempt from the declaration. Recreational trappers are not required to complete a declaration but must still obtain the Supplemental Trapping Permit. Both recreational trappers and those conducting trapping activities for livestock protection must adhere to the Fish and Wildlife Commission’s “Nontarget Capture Requirement” rule, as it relates to reporting.

Effective 48 hours after FWP is aware of the capture of any grizzly bear (after Sept. 1): ALL recreational trappers conducting trapping activities (except those using water sets or live cage traps) inside of the geographic scope identified by federal court order (see map on the next page), between Feb. 16 – Dec. 31 must adhere to the following regulations:

- All foothold trap ground sets (regardless of target species) must have an inside jaw spread of less than or equal to 5 1/2 inches.
- Snare are not allowed unless they meet all the following criteria:
 - The snare is equipped with a breakaway lock device installed on the loop end and designed to release when more than 350 pounds of force is applied;
 - The snare is fastened to an immovable object solidly secured to the ground (i.e., the use of drags is unlawful); **and**
 - The top of the loop of the snare is no more than 26 inches above the ground; in snow, 26 inches is measured from the compacted snow in a trapper’s footprint made by the full weight of the trapper.

Definitions

- Recreational Trappers: any trapper conducting trapping activities that are not undertaken in connection with livestock protection.
- Capture: evidence establishing that a grizzly bear was caught in a lawful recreational or livestock protection trap or snare, or a grizzly bear is actually caught and released from a lawful recreational or livestock protection trap or snare. This excludes any “capture” by Montana Fish, Wildlife & Parks or United States Department of Agriculture Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service - Wildlife Services. FWP will provide public notice of any capture.

Wolf Trapping Season Dates

inside of the geographic scope identified by federal court order	outside of the geographic scope identified by federal court order
Jan. 1 – Feb. 15, 2025	Dec. 2, 2024- March 15, 2025
see map on the next page	

Methods for Improving Efficiency, Selectivity, and Animal Welfare

Recreational wolf trappers are encouraged to follow the “Best Management Practices for Trapping Wolves in the United States,” which is published by the Association of Fish and Wildlife Agencies. The best management practices for trapping wolves are as follows:

- Check wolf traps before 12 p.m.;
- See below regarding type of trap and padded vs. offset and/or laminated:

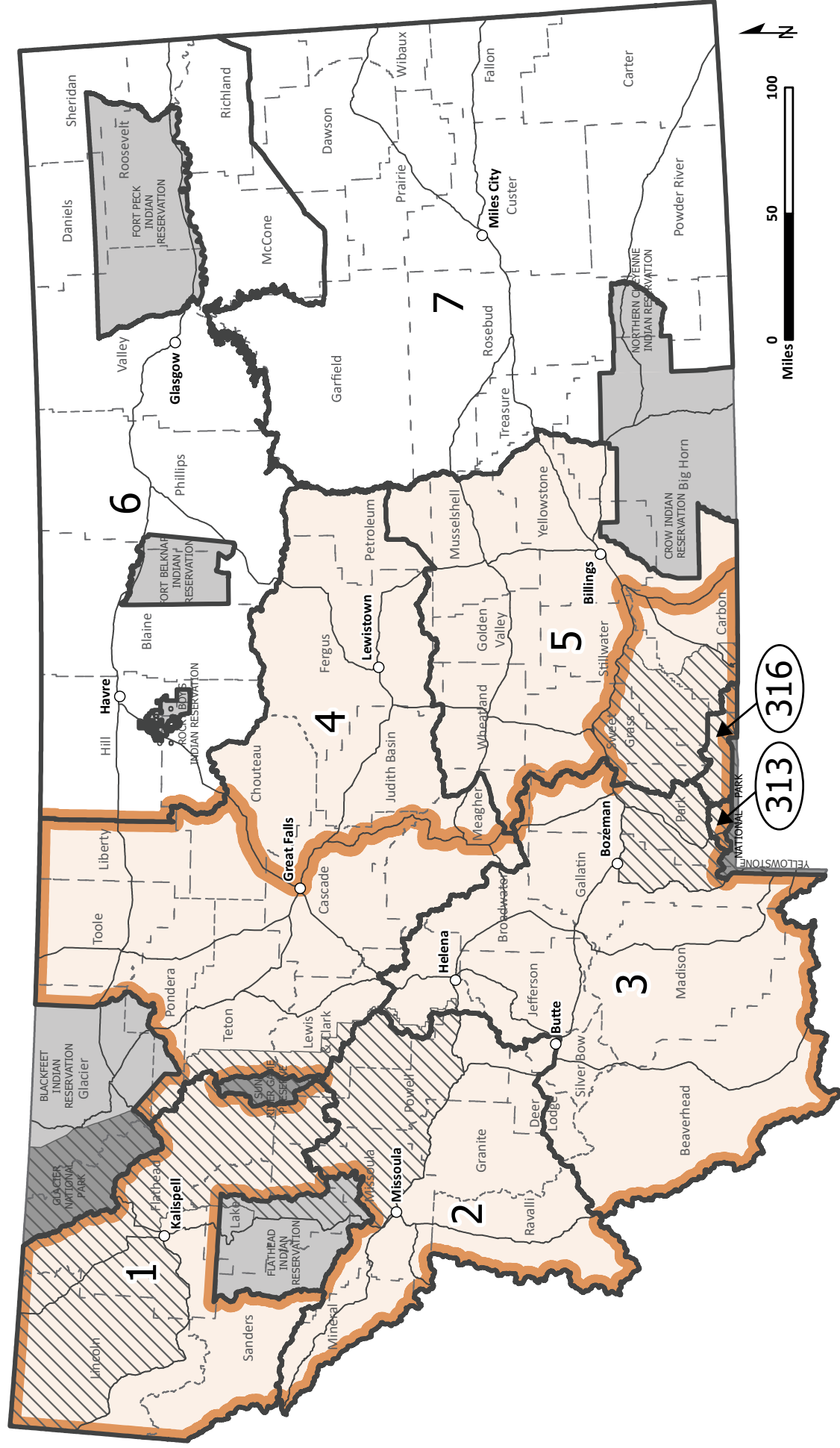
Trap Category	Jaw/Frame Characteristics	Inside Jaw/Frame Spread at Dog in inches	Inside Width at Jaw/Frame Hinge Posts in inches
Coil-spring	Padded	5-3/16" – 8"	6-7/16" – 8"
	Offset and/or laminated or wide jaws	7-1/8" – 7-1/2"	7-3/8" – 7-7/8"
Longspring	Padded	6-3/8"	5-13/16"
	Offset and/or laminated	6-1/8"	5-13/16"
Power Activated Footsnare	Smooth, round rod, 1/8" cable	8"	7-3/4"

- When snaring for coyotes, trappers are encouraged to set the length of the cable at a minimum of 96 inches (8 feet).
- Trappers are encouraged to avoid setting traps if grizzly bear are observed in an area or if grizzly bear tracks are identified.

Montana Fish, Wildlife & Parks Contacts

Headquarters: Helena	(406) 444-2535
Region 1: Kalispell	(406) 752-5501
Region 2: Missoula	(406) 542-5500
Region 3: Bozeman	(406) 577-7900
Region 4: Great Falls	(406) 454-5840
Region 5: Billings	(406) 247-2940
Region 6: Glasgow	(406) 228-3700
Region 7: Miles City	(406) 234-0900

Wolf Regional Boundaries, Lynx Protection Zones, and Geographic Scope Identified by Federal Court Order



- Wolf Region/Management Unit
- Lynx Protection Zones
- Geographic Scope Identified by the Federal Court
- Wolf Trapping Dates Jan. 1 – Feb. 15, 2025
- Free Supplemental Trapping Permit Required
- Minimum 10-pound Trap Pan Tension Area
- Closed to Hunting
- Closed to Hunting for Game Animals